In his book *Special Providence* (2001) leading American thinker Walter Russell Mead identified four approaches that have shaped American foreign policy since US independence in 1776. US relations with the world, Mead argues, can be understood in light of defining ideas advanced by significant individuals at various times in US history. Thus, according to Mead, the Hamiltonian school of foreign policy, named after first secretary of the treasury, Alexander Hamilton, 'sees the first task of the American government as promoting the health of American enterprise at home and abroad'. The Wilsonian ideal, enunciated by President Woodrow Wilson, 'believes that the United States has both a moral and a practical duty to spread its values through the world'. The Jeffersonian view, put forward by President Thomas Jefferson, 'has seen the preservation of American democracy in a dangerous world as the most pressing and vital interest of the American people'. The Jacksonian approach, crafted by President Andrew Jackson, 'represents a deeply embedded, widely spread populist and popular culture of honor, independence, courage and military pride among the American people'.[1] Makers of US foreign policy have tended to follow one or a combination of these schools of thought through most of US history though some have tried to embrace the European approach, which Mead terms 'continental realism', based on maintaining a balance of power to protect America's global interests.

A similar analysis of India's global outlook would help identify the context and underlying principles of India's foreign policy. Several scholars have attempted to explain India's world view though, unlike Mead in relation to the United States, they have not offered neat categories of Indian policy approaches. For example, in *India: A Wounded Civilization* (1976) Nobel laureate and Trinidadian of Indian descent, Sir Vidiadhar Surajprasad (V.S.) Naipaul, argues that India's problems are not external or caused because of periodic invasions or conquest. He sees India as plagued with the crisis of what he refers to as a 'wounded old civilization' that while